

SuSE Professional 9.1

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Circa 1994. I was weaned on Slackware, moved on to Red Hat, and flirted briefly with Mandrake. Along the way, I had a

GNU/Linux epiphany: call me when you have better font-support, when the X server does not hang my system or when an application stops the rude memory-dump-to-my-desktop-and-exit game. The call came in 2004. ■

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Day 1

5 CDs of SuSE Professional 9.1 dare me. I boot into a pretty blue and white installation screen—a long way from Slackware's textual installation.

Excellent layout here, good use of hyperlinks, well-presented relevant information—everything was logically placed.

I made changes, mostly because I could... showed off my 133t skills to a younger brother. Reiser FS, five partitions and a 512 MB swap, all set.

Day 2

Things change all the more... Boots into X by default. I don't like the graphical bootup, seems most unLinux-like.

SuSE took me to KDE: decent fonts all around, which, given its history, surprised me. I have heard a lot of negatives about the KDE menu—its busy layout mostly—didn't bother me. KDE wasn't aware of my monitor though, which is ridiculous since its installation detected it fine.

Oh well, the hunt for the KDE version of the Control Panel begins...

Day 3

Well hidden, in plain sight. The monitor setup is a ninja waiting in the shadows; you won't see it until it's breathing down your neck. Right-clicking on the desktop just lets you change wallpapers. The default desktop needs serious makeup; time to find out just how flexible KDE is in terms of looks.

Day 4

Very flexible. I love it... Settled for a pseudo-BeOS look, although am certain there is a better one out there. I must communicate with the world... But dude, where's my network? Some

trials and errors later, I have Internet access.

Day 5

Opera on KDE, feels like home already. Oh, I almost forgot: KDE supports system-wide mouse gestures _grins_

Day 12

Grrr, plugins! Where are my plugins?

Day 17

Multimedia on Linux?

Hmm, worth a try, at least I will get a laugh or two out of it. Foobar 2000 got the closest to my Quintessential (QCD) Player experience on Windows. I like Foobar, but QCD (not for Linux, alas) is still the best around in terms of ease-of-use. I am looking at you, Winamp.

Day 25

Let's try getting some work done with KDE! Kidding, just kidding, lower your flamethrowers. OpenOffice.org actually boots slower on KDE than on Windows. Koffice is OK, but it does not offer that MS Office feel. Since I am migrating, OOo it will be. It works. Yes, it can behave a lot better as per cross-compatibility with an MS Office document...

Day 28

I did try Gnome—the one with the ridiculously small fonts—for a while. I have neither the time nor the patience to do the font tango with Tux. Gnome, I love you mate, but you will have to wait. By the way, where is my Ximian desktop? Nautilus rocks, spatial-browsing and all.

Day 30

30 days just aren't enough. SuSE surprises me equally with its brilliance and stupidity. I am intrigued enough to give this relationship more time.